



Daler Mehndi hosted a Republic Day concert on the PartyNite metaverse from Gamitronics, becoming the first Indian to perform on the metaverse (Courtesy: Daler Mehndi on Instagram)

cards and virtual teams; SuperRare and MakersPlace for authentic digital art; and so on. Almost every virtual world, in fact, has a marketplace that sells related ware.

Last year, Sotheby's bought a plot of land in Decentraland and developed a metaverse store, which is an exact replica of its London store. In March 2021, Mike Winkelmann, a digital artist popularly known as Beeple, sold the NFT of one of his digital works for US\$69 million at Christie's. In December 2021, Adidas released its first range of NFTs (that sell for approximately 0.2ETH) at its showroom in The Sandbox. Nike has filed several trademark applications in the past couple of months for upcoming virtual rollouts. Last year, in February, the US based National Basketball Association's online platform for NFT Basketball cards registered a sale of about US\$250 million.

Gucci, Christian Dior, Ralph Lauren, all the fashion biggies have stores in 3D virtual worlds! And on the other end of the spectrum, Pizza Hut, Pringles, and Taco Bell are also selling themed NFTs.

One of the reasons for the popularity of these meta marketplaces is the ease of trading. You just set up a digital wallet, buy crypto-currency, connect your wallet to an NFT marketplace and start selling or bidding for an NFT—be it a plot of land, a collectible football card, or a rare piece of digital art.

Putting it to real use

A technology can garner attention but not sustain itself unless it proves to be really useful. Entertainment is a given, but will the meta worlds also improve the quality of our lives in the real world?

“People have been playing 3D games since the last three decades. Now, since remote working and learning is the norm, gamification will become necessary in these spaces too. Just like businesses have been developing websites on the Internet for nearly three decades, now every brand will start having 3D experiential stores. Like mobile devices replacing desktop computers, eventually holographic projections will replace TV. Holographic eyewear are being manufactured by giants like Microsoft and Apple. It is not like we will be living inside 3D, but 3D will be a superimposed element in everyone's life. Just like we have moved from button phones to touch phones, in the future we will operate gadgets using gestures as the user interfaces and user experiences shift to the 3D paradigm,” says Kypuram.

Experts say they are unable to visualise even the tip of the iceberg fully yet, because the possibilities are endless. Jog your mind, and you can list at least a dozen within a minute! Here is a small sample of what is possible.

Learning: The pandemic has taught us the importance of remote working. With the metaverse, learning could be

so much more interactive and fun at school and university levels. You can get the feel of being in a real classroom with your friends, and it would be easier for the teacher too to explain stuff with holograms and 3D working models.

Work: Effective collaboration is expected to be one of the biggest benefits of the metaverse—and one that companies like Meta and Microsoft are betting big on. Colleagues can interact and brainstorm as if they were in the same room. Plus, the standards of collaboration—especially in design—would go up significantly with MR platforms.

In December 2021, a Reuter report spoke of Boeing's plans to build its next plane in the metaverse. Its future factory will bring together engineers around the world using Microsoft HoloLens headsets, robots that speak to each other, and immersive 3D designs using holograms. I know that sounds like Tony Stark building something in the Marvel universe, but well it is bound to happen.

Events and workshops: Perhaps what people miss the most in remote working are the occasional events and workshops that liven things up and create opportunities to interact across the spectrum. Now, close-to-real events are possible in the virtual world.

NextMeet, for instance, has worked with Indian and international universities to organise virtual events and conferences. Their immersive 3D environment comes replete with *avatars* that can move around the space, 3D spatial voice, expo halls with banner hosting stands, presentation screens in the conference hall, help desks and networking lounges! VRXtream is another metaverse for events, where you can even buy spaces (stalls) and rent them out, or vice versa.

Healthcare: From training medical students to remote consultation and counselling, the metaverse is expected to benefit the medical world notably—and we can already see fragments of it in use. In a blog post that Microsoft put up last year showcasing its immersive